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handmade crochet patterns

Ember the Baby Dragon

A chunky, big-headed baby dragon with a stubby snout, scalloped wings and a ridge of spikes down the back. She sits, with folding haunches and splayed front legs.

US terms

Intermediate

4 - 5 hours



FINISHED SIZE

- About 10.5 cm (a touch over 4 in) tall seated - 103 mm by the gauge.
- 12.4 cm (just under 5 in) wingspan. About 5 cm (2 in) tail.
- A sitting dragon - her body rests on the table and her legs pose rather than lift her.

Design Code NS 08

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PATTERN OVERVIEW

A chunky, big-headed baby dragon with a stubby snout, scalloped wings and a ridge of spikes down the back. She sits, with folding haunches and splayed front legs.

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- A sitting dragon - her body rests on the table and her legs pose rather than lift her.

How the size adds up: body Rnd 1-13 is 13 rounds x 4.3 mm = 56 mm; head Rnd 1-11 is 11 rounds x 4.3 mm = 47 mm; seated together 56 + 47 = 103 mm - about 10.5 cm. Wingspan: 45 + 34 + 45 = 124 mm - just under 12.5 cm. Tail: 12 rounds x 4.3 mm = 52 mm - about 5 cm.

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SAFETY FIRST

Ember uses 10 mm safety eyes, which are a small part and a choking hazard. Lock the washers from the inside before the head is joined to the body, and pull-test each eye. She is a decorative piece, not a toy for young children, and has not been tested to ASTM F963 or EN 71. To give her to a child, embroider the eyes instead and check every seam first.

MATERIALS

- Main yarn: worsted #4, about 30 g used (buy a 50 g ball) - sage green, dusty teal, lilac or charcoal. The extra allows for tails, sewing and a second attempt.
- Contrast yarn: worsted #4, about 20 g in a contrast cream or pale gold - used for the wings, horns and spikes, so all the details match.
- Hook: 3.5 mm (US E/4).
- Eyes: 2 x 10 mm safety eyes - slit-pupil dragon eyes if you can get them.
- Also needed: polyester fibre fill about 10 g; tapestry needle; stitch markers; pins.

GAUGE

Gauge: about 4.5 mm per stitch and 4.3 mm per round. Check on the body after Rnd 5 - 30 stitches should measure about 43 mm across when stuffed. If your stitches are wider, crochet more tightly or drop to a 3.0 mm hook or the stuffing will show.

ABBREVIATIONS

MR magic ring

ch chain

sc single crochet

hdc half double crochet

dc double crochet

inc increase (2 sc in one st)

dec invisible decrease

sl st slip stitch

FO fasten off

(n) stitch count at round end

CONSTRUCTION & TECHNIQUES

Work in a continuous spiral unless a row says to turn; mark the first stitch of every round. The wings and the spike strip are the exceptions - both are worked flat. Work every stitch through both loops unless a note says otherwise.

1. The magic ring

Every piece begins with a magic ring. Pull the tail tight once the first round is complete.

2. Working in a spiral

Keep a stitch marker in the first stitch of every round; there is no join to count from.

3. Matched open joins

Ember's head and her neck are BOTH left open at 18 stitches, so the two edges are the same size and can be ladder-stitched together cleanly. This is the single most important structural detail - the head is heavy and this joint carries all of it. Do not close the head down to a point; stop at 18 stitches. Closing a heavy dragon head down to 6 stitches leaves a small gathered point sewn to a wide neck ring - a tiny seam carrying a big head, which is exactly why a dragon's head flops.

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Head - main colour (worked top-down)

Worked top-down and LEFT OPEN - do not close it and do not fasten off. A big head is what makes a dragon read as a baby dragon. Two straight rounds only, then the decreases.

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	-
R2	inc in each st around	(12)	-
R3	[sc, inc] x 6	(18)	-
R4	[2 sc, inc] x 6	(24)	-
R5	[3 sc, inc] x 6	(30)	-
R6	[4 sc, inc] x 6	(36)	head at full width
R7	sc in each st around	(36)	eyes at R7 - R8
R8	sc in each st around	(36)	-
R9	[4 sc, dec] x 6	(30)	-
R10	[3 sc, dec] x 6	(24)	stuff firmly
R11	[2 sc, dec] x 6	(18)	LEAVE OPEN - matches neck

Finish: stuff the head firmly. Leave the open 18-stitch edge for sewing to the body's neck (a long tail is optional). The snout is sewn on next, then the eyes, BEFORE the head is joined.

2. Snout - main colour (make 1)

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	-
R2	[sc, inc] x 3	(9)	-
R3	[2 sc, inc] x 3	(12)	-

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R4	sc in each st around	(12)	-
R5	sc in each st around	(12)	-

Finish: FO with a long tail and stuff lightly. Pin centred on Rnds 8-11 of the head, just below the eye line, and sew all the way around. It must project past the curve of the head, not sit flush - a dragon without a projecting snout reads as a bear. Embroider two small nostrils at the tip.

3. Body - main colour (worked bottom-up)

Worked bottom-up. The neck is left open at 18 stitches so the head can be seated on it. Pack the neck firmly before you join the head - a soft neck is what lets the head flop forward.

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	-
R2	inc in each st around	(12)	-
R3	[sc, inc] x 6	(18)	-
R4	[2 sc, inc] x 6	(24)	tail attaches R4 - R6
R5	[3 sc, inc] x 6	(30)	full width - check gauge
R6	sc in each st around	(30)	back legs at R6
R7	sc in each st around	(30)	-
R8	sc in each st around	(30)	front legs at R8
R9	sc in each st around	(30)	-
R10	[3 sc, dec] x 6	(24)	wings at R10 - R11
R11	sc in each st around	(24)	-
R12	[2 sc, dec] x 6	(18)	stuff firmly
R13	sc in each st around	(18)	LEAVE THE NECK OPEN

Finish: FO with a 40 cm tail; do not close. When you join the head, ladder-stitch all the way around and then make a second pass and pull it tight - this joint carries the whole head.

4. Legs - main colour (make 4)

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	all four
R2	[sc, inc] x 3	(9)	all four
R3	sc in each st around	(9)	all four
R4	sc in each st around	(9)	all four
R5	sc in each st around	(9)	all four
R6	sc in each st around	(9)	BACK legs finish here
R7	sc in each st around	(9)	front legs only
R8	sc in each st around	(9)	front legs only

Finish: stuff the lower half lightly and leave the top 3 rounds soft; FO with a long tail. Press the 9-stitch opening flat - 4 stitches in front, 4 behind, the odd stitch tucked into the fold - and the leg mouth sews shut

when you attach it. The pairs are different lengths on purpose: back legs (6 rnd / 26 mm) attach at Rnd 6, 26 mm up; front legs (8 rnd / 34 mm) attach at Rnd 8, 34 mm up. A higher join needs a longer leg so all four feet reach the table. Sew each pair about 8 stitches apart; angle the back legs under as haunches and the front legs slightly forward. The body rests on the table - the legs pose, they don't lift her.

5. Tail - main colour

Worked from the tip up so it tapers naturally.

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	4 sc in MR	(4)	tip
R2	sc in each st around	(4)	-
R3	[sc, inc] x 2	(6)	-
R4	sc in each st around	(6)	-
R5	sc in each st around	(6)	-
R6	[2 sc, inc] x 2	(8)	-
R7	sc in each st around	(8)	-
R8	sc in each st around	(8)	-
R9	[3 sc, inc] x 2	(10)	-
R10	sc in each st around	(10)	-
R11	sc in each st around	(10)	-
R12	sc in each st around	(10)	base

Finish: stuff lightly, FO with a long tail, flatten the open end and sew it to the back of the body at Rnds 4-6.

6. Horns - contrast colour (make 2)

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	4 sc in MR	(4)	-
R2	sc in each st around	(4)	-
R3	[sc, inc] x 2	(6)	-
R4	sc in each st around	(6)	-
R5	sc in each st around	(6)	-

Finish: do not stuff; FO with a long tail. Sew to the crown of the head, 6 stitches apart, angled back.

7. Wings - contrast colour (make 2, worked flat)

Ch 11. Work in turned rows (ch 1 and turn at each row end):

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
Found	ch 11	-	-
Row 1	from the 2nd ch: sc in 4, hdc in 3, dc in 3	(10)	-
Row 2	sc in 3, hdc in 3, dc in 4	(10)	-
Row 3	sc in 2, hdc in 4, dc in 4	(10)	-
Row 4	sl st in first 2, (sc, hdc, dc, hdc, sc) all in next st, sl st in next 2, (sc, hdc, dc, hdc, sc) all in next st, sl st in last 4	-	scalloped edge - FO with a 25 cm tail

The scallop maths: the slip-stitch anchors are $2 + 2 + 4 = 8$ stitches; the two shells each fan from a single stitch (2 more), so all 10 stitches of Row 3 are consumed and nothing is left over. Pin the straight inner edge across Rnds 10-11 and sew the WHOLE edge so the scalloped edge stays free.

8. Spike strip - contrast colour

One continuous strip sewn down the centre back from crown to tail tip - nine spikes: 3 on the head, 4 on the body, 2 on the tail.

Ch 4. Sc in the 2nd ch from the hook, then work this group NINE times: ch 4, sl st in the 2nd ch from the hook, sc in the next ch, hdc in the next ch. Then sc in the next 2 and FO with a long tail.

The strip is one starting chain of 4 plus nine chain-4 spike units - ten chain-4 groups and 40 chains in total, worked end to end (not a single 40-chain). Each group makes one small cone (about 10 mm tall); the last stitch of one group is where the next begins, so the nine spikes form one continuous ridge with no gaps.

The strip is about 13.5-15 cm long - slightly under the crown-to-tail path, so it goes on slightly snug. PIN it from crown to tail tip first; if it runs short add one more spike (about 13.5 mm), if long unpick from the plain end. The spikes deliberately touch - do not add plain stitches between them.



On the hook - what your rounds should look like as they grow

FINISHING & ASSEMBLY

- Assembly - work in this order:
 1. Snout to the head, centred on Rnds 8-11, below the eye line.
 2. Eyes between Rnds 7 and 8, 8 stitches apart, just above the snout. Fit the washers BEFORE the head is joined - once closed you cannot reach inside.
 3. Horns to the crown, 6 stitches apart, angled back.
 4. Head to body: both edges open at 18 stitches. Pack the neck firmly, seat the head and ladder-stitch around, then a second tight pass.
 5. Legs: back pair to Rnd 6, front pair to Rnd 8, angled as described.
 6. Tail to the back of the body at Rnds 4-6.
 7. Wings across Rnds 10-11, sewn along the whole straight edge.

8. Spike strip LAST - pin from crown to tail tip before you sew a single stitch.

TROUBLESHOOTING

- **Head flops forward.**

Pack the neck firmly before closing and make the second ladder-stitch pass tight. If it still moves, the edges did not match - both head and neck must be open at 18 stitches.

- **Rocks back onto haunches.**

The legs are all the same length and they cannot be. Back legs attach 26 mm up, front 34 mm up - work the back legs 6 rounds and the front 8.

- **Will not sit.**

Legs sewn too high, or the base is under-stuffed. Back legs on Rnd 6, front on Rnd 8; keep the lower body firm enough to sit on.

- **Wings droop.**

Sew along the whole straight inner edge, not just the top corner.

- **Spike strip is the wrong length / curves.**

It is nine chain-4 spike units on one starting chain - ten chain-4 groups worked end to end, not a single 40-chain. Pin the entire strip from crown to tail before sewing; add or unpick a spike as needed. This is the most visible seam.

- **Looks like a bear.**

The snout is missing or under-stuffed - it must project past the dome of the head.

- **Stuffing shows through.**

Gauge too loose - 30 stitches should measure 43 mm across. Crochet tighter or drop to a 3.0 mm hook.

COLORWAYS



Sage green



Dusty teal



Lilac



Charcoal



Blush pink

HELPFUL TIPS

- The continuous spike ridge runs from crown to tail tip - it is sewn on last and pinned before any stitch.

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Safety reminder

This pattern has not been tested to a toy-safety standard (ASTM F963 / EN 71) and uses 10 mm safety eyes. Finished items made for sale must be assessed by the seller against local toy-safety laws; for young children, embroider the eyes.

Happy crocheting!

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